

Using Stellarium

Student activity

Name _____ Date _____

Stellarium is a free, open-source software that enables your computer to act as a planetarium. It shows a realistic sky in 3D and calculates the positions of the Sun, Moon, planets, stars, and many other astronomical objects.

Stellarium is useful for planning astronomical observing sessions. In this lesson you will learn some basic information about how to use Stellarium.

Procedure

1. Open the *Stellarium* program
2. Spend several minutes exploring the program.
3. Open the *Location* window and choose Charlotte.
4. Turning off atmosphere will help make the stars visible all the time.
5. Show different menus:
 - Location [F6]
 - Date/Time [F5]
 - Sky and Viewing Options [F4]

Suggested Activities

6. Choose multiple locations and write down their observations.
7. Choose a location near the north pole, one near the south pole, and one near the equator.
8. Click on the speed buttons to speed up the rotation. Describe the paths of the stars. Which way does the sky “rotate”?